When Public Transportation Depends on a Phone: An Ethical Analysis of Metra and the Ventra App

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Introduction

Public transportation is supposed to be one of the most accessible systems in everyday life, but that access becomes more and more complicated when it depends on a working smartphone. For many riders, using an app to buy a train ticket is convenient and normal. It can save time, reduce the need for physical tickets, and make travel and transportation feel more efficient. However, that convenience isn't experienced equally by everyone. When a public transportation system becomes too dependent on smartphone and technology-based ticketing, it can create problems for riders who don't have reliable phones, stable data, digital payment access, or the ability to use an app while traveling.

This project focuses on Metra's reliance on the Ventra app, especially during the February 2024 rollout of new fares and procedures. During that rollout, the Ventra app crashed, which made it difficult or impossible for some riders to buy or show mobile tickets. This wasn't just some small technical problem. It showed a larger ethical issue about what happens when public services rely heavily on private personal technology. If a rider's ability to use public transportation depends on their phone working correctly, then access to that service becomes less equal. A dead battery, a glitching app, poor service, limited internet data, or lack of digital payment access can all become barriers.

The ethical issue in this case isn't that the Ventra app exists or that digital ticketing is always wrong. Digital ticketing can be useful, and for many riders it probably makes the process a lot smoother. The problem is when the app becomes too central and dependent on the system while other options become less and less available. Public transportation serves a wide range of people, including commuters, students, older adults, lower-income riders, and people with

different levels of digital access. Because of that, Metra has an ethical responsibility to make sure modernization doesn't leave some of those riders behind.

This project argues that Metra's heavy reliance on the Ventra app is ethically problematic because a public transportation system shouldn't make access depend too heavily on smartphone-based technology. From a care ethics perspective, the system didn't fully account for the real needs and vulnerabilities of its riders who may struggle with technology access. From a Kantian perspective, the system treated some riders as secondary in favor of efficiency and modernization instead of fully respecting them as people with their own transportation needs. By looking at this case through both perspectives, it shows that the Ventra app failure wasn't just a technology problem, but part of a larger dilemma about fairness, access, and responsibility in public transportation.

Case Study

My case study focuses on Metra's growing reliance on the Ventra app for ticket sales and rider access, especially during the February 2024 rollout of new fares and procedures. On the first day of the rollout, the Ventra app crashed, which prevented many riders from buying or showing their tickets. At the same time, many ticket windows had already been closed, meaning the digital system was no longer just a convenience for some riders, but one of the main ways to access public transportation. According to Norkol and Hernandez, "Metra customers, already facing new fares this week, have grappled with technological difficulties for two days after the Ventra app crashed, preventing the mobile sale of tickets" (2024). Some riders were allowed onboard without paying if they showed the broken app, but many others were left with confusion, delays, and uncertainty.

The technology at the center of this case is the Ventra app, which functions as a digital tool for buying and showing tickets in the Chicago-area public transportation system. Metra's increased reliance on the app reflects a more broader shift in public transportation toward digital systems. These systems are meant to improve efficiency, modernize services, and reduce reliance on older methods such as staffed ticket windows or physical ticket purchasing areas. In theory, this kind of transition can offer real benefits. App-based ticketing can simplify payment, reduce wait times, and make the transit experience more smooth for many riders. However, the February 2024 outage shows that these benefits also come with risks. When the app failed, access to a basic public service became uncertain for commuters who depended on their phones as their main way of buying and showing tickets.

This case matters because it shows how access to public transportation can become tied to a private device that can fail in many ways. A phone can die, lose service, glitch, run out of data, or simply not work at the moment a person needs it most. Once a public service starts depending heavily on a device like that, the issue becomes bigger than an inconvenience. It raises ethical questions about fairness, access, and responsibility. The Metra case is not just about a technical problem. It is also about how a public system is designed and what it assumes about the people expected to use it.

Research on digital transit systems also shows that this problem goes beyond one instance of an app outage. Golub et al. point out that "many transit riders lack access to banking, internet or smartphone connectivity" (2022). That matters because it makes the Metra case part of a larger issue in public transportation. A system that relies on apps and digital payments may look efficient and modern, but it does not affect everyone the same way. Riders with smartphones, stable data, banking access, and stronger digital skills are much more likely to

move through the system easily. Riders without those things are more likely to face barriers. Because of that, the case becomes an ethical issue, not just a practical one.

Durand et al. also add another important point when they write that “digital technologies facilitate a self-service approach that paradoxically makes some people more dependent on others” (2023). This helps explain why digital systems cannot simply be treated as neutral improvements. Smartphone-based systems are often presented as more convenient and independent, but for some riders they can create more stress, confusion, and dependence. Durand et al. also explain that “the lack of ownership of the right devices, such as a computer or a smartphone, is an obvious obstacle to reaping benefits of digitalisation” (2023). In this case, the benefits of digital ticketing only fully work for people who already have the right devices and the ability to use them reliably.

The main moral agents in this case are Metra, the Ventra app provider, and the transit staff who had to respond to the outage in real time. Metra is the most important moral agent because it is the transit agency responsible for fare policy, ticket access, and the overall structure of the system. Metra did not just use the Ventra app as an extra option. It also made decisions that increased rider dependence on digital ticketing, including reducing access to staffed ticket windows while rolling out new fare procedures. That choice is ethically important because closing ticket windows made the app failure more serious. If more non-digital options had been available, the outage may still have been frustrating, but riders would’ve had clearer alternatives.

The Ventra app provider is also a moral agent because the company behind the app was responsible for maintaining a system that riders were expected to rely on. Once an app becomes one of the main ways people access public transportation, its reliability becomes more than a customer service issue. The app provider had a responsibility to make sure the system could

handle demand, especially during a major fare change when many riders would be using it at the same time. The provider's decisions about testing, maintenance, design, and outage response all affected whether riders could actually use the service.

Transit staff and conductors also had moral responsibilities, although their role was more limited. They were not the people who designed the app or decided to close ticket windows, but they were the ones who had to deal with riders when the system failed. Their decisions mattered in the moment because they had to decide how to treat riders who could not buy or show tickets because of the app. Some riders were reportedly allowed onboard if they showed the broken app, which shows that staff had to use judgment and flexibility. This does not make transit staff responsible for the larger failure, but it does show how frontline workers became part of the ethical situation because they had to manage the consequences of decisions made above them.

The moral significance of this case comes from what is at stake for the people affected. The directly affected stakeholders include commuters, students, workers, older adults, lower-income riders, and anyone who depends on Metra to get to school, work, appointments, or other important places. Indirectly affected stakeholders include transit staff, Metra administrators, the company behind the app, and the general public that depends on the system being fair and reliable. There are clear benefits to app-based ticketing, including convenience, speed, modernization, and possibly lower operating costs. At the same time, the harms are also serious. If the app fails, or if a rider's phone dies or loses service, that rider may suddenly lose access to a public service they rely on. Since transportation is connected to work, education, appointments, and daily movement, these harms can affect much more than convenience.

This case also raises issues of equality and justice. A smartphone-based transit system does not affect all riders in the same way. Riders with newer phones, stable internet, stronger

digital skills, and more financial security are more likely to benefit from the system. Riders without those things are more likely to experience delays, confusion, or exclusion. That means the system can reinforce inequalities that already exist. Public transportation is supposed to be accessible to everyone, and yet an app-based system can make it feel like using a public service depends on having the newest iPhone or unlimited data.

This also creates a dilemma around accountability. If the app fails, the rider is often the person who feels the consequences first, even though the larger system design also created the vulnerability. The rider may be delayed, confused, or unable to prove payment, but the problem didn't come only from the rider's personal device or choices. It also came from the decision to make digital access so central to the system. Because of that, this case raises important questions about who is responsible when public transportation depends on technology that can break down. It sets up a larger ethical analysis about fairness, access, responsibility, and how public services should protect riders when digital systems fail.

Nel Noddings' Ethics of Care Analysis

To evaluate this case, I am using feminist ethical theory, specifically Nel Noddings' ethics of care. This theory focuses on relationships, dependence, and care instead of only looking at the consequences or the rules. I believe this theory works well for the Metra and Ventra case because public transportation is something people actually depend on in their daily lives. For many people, it's how they get to work, school, appointments, and other responsibilities. Because of that, the issue isn't just that the Ventra app crashed. The bigger question is whether a public transportation system that relies so heavily on smartphone access is really caring for the people who need to use it. Using Noddings' procedure and theories, I will look at the actions

being considered, the three elements of caring, whether caring for riders in this way would seriously harm Metra's ability to function, and then what conclusion follows up from that.

Step 1: Identify the Action Under Consideration

Noddings described Step 1 as identifying the action under consideration. The action under consideration is Metra's decision to rely heavily on the Ventra app and smartphone-based ticketing while also reducing other ways for riders to buy or access tickets. The ethical issue is not only that the Ventra app crashed during the February 2024 fare rollout, but the bigger issue is that the system was already set up in a way that made many riders depend on the app in the first place. Since ticket windows had already been closed and digital access had become more important, the app failure showed a deeper problem with the structure of the system. From the perspective of feminist ethical theory, this matters because the case is not just about a technical mistake. It's about whether Metra's decision showed enough care for the riders who rely on public transportation.

Step 2: Consider the Three Elements of Ethical Caring

The second step asks us to consider the three elements of ethical caring and decide what is best for the people affected by the decision. The first element of ethical caring is apprehending the other's reality, which means trying to understand the actual life, needs, and situation of the person being cared for. In this case, that means Metra would need to understand what riders' lives are actually like, especially commuters, students, workers, older adults, lower-income riders, and people with limited digital access. App-based ticketing doesn't affect everyone the same way. Some riders have newer phones, stable data, online banking, and strong digital skills,

while others don't. Golub et al. (2022) show that some transit riders don't have reliable access to things like smartphones, internet, or banking, which makes digital payment systems harder for them to use. That means a phone-based ticketing system can create real barriers for riders who cannot reliably use the app every time they need transportation.

The second and third elements are engrossment and motivational displacement. Engrossment means paying real attention to another person's well-being, while motivational displacement means being guided by that person's needs rather than mainly by one's own convenience. In this case, Metra would need to consider not only efficiency and modernization, but also whether riders can actually use the system without unnecessary stress or exclusion. Durand et al. wrote that "malfunctioning software, old devices, unstable operating systems, dead batteries, a limited data bundle, no wired internet and high costs can also be barriers" (2023). This connects directly to the Metra case because the Ventra app depends on riders having a working phone, enough battery, stable software, and reliable access to the app. From a feminist ethics perspective, Metra would need to consider these everyday problems because they shape whether riders can actually use the system.

Step 3: Consider Whether Caring for Riders Would Seriously Harm Metra

The third step is to consider whether caring for the riders in this situation would seriously harm Metra's ability to function. Care ethics doesn't mean that Metra has to ignore its own limits or practical needs. Metra still has to manage costs, update its systems, reduce unnecessary delays, and keep transportation running for a large number of people. It wouldn't be fair to pretend that keeping older systems in place has no cost. If Metra kept more staffed ticket windows open, trained employees for backup procedures, or maintained non-digital ticket

options, it would likely require more money, staffing, planning, and time. It could also make the system less efficient than a mostly digital model.

However, those sacrifices don't seem serious enough to make caring for riders unreasonable. Metra wouldn't have to give up digital ticketing completely. It would also not have to stop modernizing its system. The real question is whether Metra should give up some efficiency and cost savings in order to keep public transportation accessible when the app fails or when riders cannot use it. From a care ethics perspective, that seems like a reasonable trade-off. Public transportation is not just a private convenience or optional service. People rely on it to get to work, school, appointments, and other responsibilities. Because of that, Metra's responsibility is not only to make ticketing faster for the average rider, but also to make sure the system still works for people who are more vulnerable to digital barriers.

A stronger backup system might mean keeping some ticket windows open in important locations, allowing more in-person purchasing options, creating clearer procedures for app outages, or making sure conductors have consistent instructions when riders cannot access mobile tickets. These options might be less efficient than relying heavily on the app, but they would not destroy Metra's ability to operate. Instead, they would require Metra to accept that accessibility sometimes costs more than pure efficiency. From this perspective, caring for riders would require Metra to give up some convenience, savings, or speed, but not its basic ability to function. That means the burden on Metra is real, but it is not serious enough to outweigh the needs of riders who depend on the system.

Step 4: Care Ethics Conclusion

Using care ethics, Metra's heavy reliance on the Ventra app is ethically weak because it doesn't fully account for the needs of the riders who depend on the system. The issue isn't that digital ticketing exists at all, because app-based access can be helpful and convenient for many people, possibly even the majority of riders. The problem is that the system became too dependent on the app while reducing other ways for riders to access tickets. From this perspective, Metra should have paid closer attention to the reality of riders who do not have reliable phones, online banking access, stable data, or strong digital skills. A more ethical approach would keep digital ticketing as one option while also maintaining reliable alternatives when technology fails. Since caring for riders would require Metra to give up some efficiency but would not seriously harm its ability to operate, care ethics suggests that Metra should not rely so heavily on smartphone-based ticketing unless it also provides fair and dependable backup options.

Kantian Ethics Theory Analysis

Metra's reliance on the Ventra app raises a real ethical issue about public transportation and the people who depend on it. When the Ventra app crashed during the February 2024 rollout of new fares and protocols, many riders were left unable to buy or show their tickets. That matters because public transportation isn't just an extra inconvenience for these people. For many people, it's how they get to work, school, appointments, and many other important places. Kant's ethical theory helps evaluate this case because it focuses on duty, respect, and whether people are treated as ends in themselves rather than just a part of someone else's goal. In this case, the question is whether Metra's heavy reliance on smartphone-based ticketing respected

riders as people with their own needs, or whether some riders were treated as less important than efficiency and modernization.

Step 1: Identify the action under consideration

The first step Kant highlights is to identify the action under consideration. In this case, the action under consideration is Metra's decision to rely mostly on the Ventra app and smartphone-based ticketing while reducing other ways for riders to buy or access tickets. The problem isn't only that the Ventra app had crashed during that first fare rollout. The bigger issue was that the system was already set up in the way that made many riders depend on the app in the first place. According to Norkol and Hernandez, "Metra customers, already facing new fares this week, have grappled with technological difficulties for two days after the Ventra app crashed, preventing the mobile sale of tickets" (2024). Since ticket windows had already been closed down, the app failure became more than just a simple technical inconvenience, it affected whether some riders could actually access public transportation when they needed it.

Step 2: Determine whether everyone was treated as ends in themselves

The second step is to determine whether everyone was treated as ends in themselves. In Kant's theory, people should be respected as rational people with their own goals, needs, and dignity. In this case, the riders' goals were basic and reasonable. All they wanted was to get to work, school, home, appointments, and other responsibilities. A public transportation system is supposed to recognize these goals as important instead of just resting riders like they simply have to adjust to whatever system is most efficient and cheap for the agency.

Metra's app-based system can be considered as respectful to some riders as in some ways, digital ticketing is more convenient. It can save time, make payment easier, and make the transit process smoother. However, the issue is that not every rider can experience that digital system the same way. Some riders have smartphones, stable data, banking access, and strong digital skills, while others do not. If Metra builds ticket access around the assumption that everyone has a working smartphone and digital payment access, then it's not fully respecting the reality of all riders. Public transportation is supposed to be accessible to everyone, but app-based systems can make it feel like access depends on having the newest technology or unlimited data. From a Kantian point of view, that's a problem because riders without reliable digital access still have legitimate transportation needs.

Step 3: Determine whether anyone was simply used as means

The third step is to determine whether anyone was simply used as a means to accomplish someone else's goals. In this case, Metra's goals likely included efficiency, modernization, reducing costs, and making ticketing faster. These goals aren't necessarily wrong, a transportation agency does need to update its systems and manage resources. However, Kantian ethics asks whether people are being used to reach those goals without enough respect for their own needs.

If Metra's system becomes more efficient by shifting the responsibility onto the riders to have the right phone, enough battery, stable software, internet access, digital payment, and digital skills, then some riders are carrying the burden of the system's modernization. Riders who can't use the app reliably may be delayed, confused, or unable to prove that they paid for the tickets. Even if Metra didn't intend to harm anyone, the design of the system can still treat some

riders as secondary to the goal of efficiency and cheapness. That suggests some riders were partly used as a means toward modernization rather than fully treated as people with their own important needs.

Step 4: Determine the moral conclusion

The moral conclusion is that Metra's heavy reliance on smartphone-based ticketing is ethically problematic from a Kantian perspective. The problem isn't that the Ventra app exists or that digital ticketing is always wrong. Digital ticketing can be useful and respectful when it's one option among others. However, the ethical issue rises when that system becomes too dependent on the app while other access points are reduced or entirely removed. That made some riders carry the risk of technological failure in a way that didn't fully respect their needs and goals.

Kant's ethical theory would say that Metra should treat riders as ends in themselves by respecting their basic goal of accessing public transportation. It shouldn't structure the system in a way that makes some riders harder to accommodate just because they don't fit the digital model. A more ethical approach would've been to keep the Ventra app as a useful and digital option while also keeping fair and dependable alternatives for riders who can't use the app such as the old ticket booths. Therefore, according to Kant's theory, Metra's heavy reliance on the Ventra app was ethically weak because it focused too much on efficiency and not enough on riders' needs.

Critique of Analysis

My previous ethical analyses used two different theories to look at the Metra and Ventra app case. The first one used Nel Noddings' ethics of care, which we discussed as part of

feminist ethical theory. The second one used Kant's ethical theory. Both analyses ended up reaching around the similar conclusion, that being that Metra's heavy reliance on the Ventra app was ethically weak because it made public transportation too dependent on technology and smartphone access and created barriers for some riders. However, the two theories got to that conclusion in different ways, both having strengths and weaknesses.

One strength of the care ethics analysis was that it focused on the actual riders and their experiences. Instead of only asking whether the Ventra app made the system faster or more modern, it also asked whether the system paid attention to the people who actually rely on public transportation. This worked well because the case isn't just about an app crashing. It's about commuters, students, older adults, lower-income riders, and people who may not have reliable digital access. Care ethics made it easier to treat stress, confusion, dependence, and exclusion as real ethical problems. That was useful because a transit system can look efficient from the outside while still making life harder for certain riders.

The weakness of the care ethics analysis is that it may have leaned a bit too far toward the rider's side without fully dealing with Metra's practical limits. Metra still has to think about costs, staffing, technology, and how to keep a transportation system running. The analysis argued that backup options or non-digital alternatives wouldn't seriously harm Metra's ability to function, but it didn't really prove that. It would've been stronger if it maybe included more information about how expensive ticket windows are, or how many people used the app, or what backup systems Metra could realistically keep. Without that, the point still stands, but it doesn't fully answer the practical side of the dilemma.

The Kantian analysis had a different type of strength. It gave a clearer way to judge the issue by asking whether riders were treated as ends in themselves or partly used as a means

toward efficiency and modernization. This was helpful because it made the analysis less about emotion and more so about respect. From a Kantian view, riders aren't just users in a system. They're people with their own goals, like getting to work, school, appointments, and home. It made the argument sharper because it showed that the ethical dilemma wasn't only the app failure, but also whether the system respected all riders equally.

The weakness of the Kantian analysis is that it might've made the situation sound more direct than it actually is. Kant's theory works really well when someone is clearly being used as a tool, but the Metra case is a bit more complicated. Metra may not have intended to treat riders as less important. It may have actually believed that app-based ticketing would help most riders and improve the system overall. The analysis did however mention that the intention isn't the only issue because the design of the system also matters. Still, it could've explained more clearly that Metra wasn't necessarily using riders on purpose, but that the design of the system still risked putting efficiency above some riders' needs.

Another weakness in both analyses is that they both focused more on the harms of digital ticketing than also on the benefits. For many riders, the Ventra app is a breakthrough. It's faster, easier, and more convenient than buying tickets in person at a booth. The problem is when it becomes too relied on and then other options disappear. Both analyses got to that point, but they could have spent more time balancing the benefits of the app with the harm it can cause for riders who can't use it reliably.

Perhaps a different ethical theory could have provided a better answer in some ways. Utilitarianism, for example, would force the analysis to weigh the benefits and harms for everyone affected. That could've been more useful because public transportation involves large numbers of people and limited resources. An analysis on utilitarianism would compare the

convenience, speed, and cost savings of an app-based ticketing while also looking into the exclusion, confusion, and the unequal access faced by some of the riders. However, utilitarianism isn't perfect either in that if most riders benefit from the app, it might make the harms faced by smaller or more vulnerable groups appear less important. Because of that, utilitarianism might give a more broad answer, but not necessarily a better one.

The analysis could be strengthened by adding more evidence and stronger counterarguments. More information about Metra's costs, app usage, ticket window closures, and backup procedures would make the evaluation make more sense for all sides. It would also separate the two related issues: both the app outage on that February day and the larger dilemma of relying too heavily on technology and smartphone access. Overall, the care ethics analysis was strongest at showing how the system affects real people, while Kant's theory was strongest at showing why riders should be respected as people with their own goals.

Personal Reflection

Throughout this project, I learned that technology ethics is a lot more complicated than just asking whether a certain device is good or bad. At first, my topic looked really simple because I was simply starting out with the idea of phone usage and addiction, and then I transitioned into looking at Metra's reliance on the Ventra app and smartphone-based ticketing. It seemed like the main issue was that the app crashed and made it harder for people to buy or show tickets. However, as I kept working through and researching about the project, I realized that the bigger issue was how public transportation is becoming more dependent on personal technology.

One of the biggest things I learned is that convenience isn't always the same thing as fairness. For many people, buying a ticket through an app is probably faster and easier. I am in fact one of those people as I prefer doing digital ticketing as I don't often carry cash on me. However, at the same time, this project made me think about what happens when that convenience becomes the main option. If someone's phone dies, glitches, loses service, or if they don't have a smartphone at all, then a public service can suddenly become harder to access. That made me see digital access as more than just a problem because it became a public issue where a basic system was beginning to depend on it.

One challenge I had during this project was trying not to repeat the same point over and over again. A lot of my case came back to the same idea: public transportation should be accessible, and app-based systems can create all sorts of barriers. Since it was the main idea of my topic, it was sometimes hard to expand the argument without making it sound repetitive. I had to think more carefully about what each ethical theory added and their contributions to the case. Care ethics helped me focus on riders' needs and experiences, while Kant's theory helped me focus more on respect, duty, and whether riders were being treated as ends in themselves. Even though both theories led me to a similar conclusion, they helped me understand the case in different ways.

I think one thing I did well was choosing a topic that connected to my actual life. I use Metra four times a week, so this wasn't just a random case to me. I see people use the Ventra app, I notice the ticket booths standing devoid of people, and I know how frustrating it can be when you don't have data to open the app or the program is just not loading. Because of that, the case felt a lot more real and easier to care about. It also helped me avoid writing about technology in a vague way, because I had a specific example and experience in mind.

One thing I probably could've done better is look more into Metra's side of the situation. I focused a lot on riders and access, but I could've researched more about why Metra closed ticket windows, how much the app is used, and what backup systems already exist. That would've made my analyses more balanced and less biased. I still think that reliable alternatives are important, but a stronger analysis with the ethical theories would explain the challenges more clearly.

A part of this project I would like to learn more about is the larger digital divide in public services. This issue doesn't just apply to transportation but to other services as well. Phones and internet access are needed for school, banking, healthcare, jobs, government forms, and so much of daily life. This project made me more aware of how easily technology can become required without people really noticing.

What started out as researching phone usage in daily life transitioned into a case about the Ventra app that became a larger issue about access, fairness, and public systems depending on phones. It helped me see that technology can be useful and efficient while still creating problems for people who don't have the same resources or options.

Conclusion

Metra's reliance on the Ventra app shows that technology in public services can be helpful while still creating serious ethical problems. The main issue isn't that the Ventra app exists or that digital ticketing is automatically wrong. For many riders, the app is probably faster, easier, and more convenient than buying tickets in person. The problem is that the system became too dependent on smartphone-based access while other options became less available. When the app crashed during the February 2024 fare rollout, it showed how quickly a digital

convenience can become a barrier when people don't have another reliable way to access the service.

The case study showed that this issue involves more than just a technical failure. Metra, the Ventra app provider, and transit staff all had different roles in the situation. Metra was responsible for the structure of the system, including the decision to rely more heavily on digital ticketing while reducing staffed ticket windows. The Ventra app provider was responsible for maintaining a system that riders were expected to depend on. Transit staff and conductors were left to respond in real time when riders couldn't buy or show tickets. This created an ethical dilemma about responsibility, because the rider often feels the consequences first even though the vulnerability came from the larger system design.

The care ethics analysis showed why this case matters on a human level. Public transportation isn't just a random service that people use for convenience. Many people rely on it to get to work, school, appointments, and other responsibilities. From a care ethics perspective, Metra should've paid closer attention to the actual lives of riders, especially people who may not have reliable phones, stable data, banking access, or strong digital skills. Caring for those riders wouldn't require Metra to completely just give up on digital ticketing or stop modernizing. It would require Metra to accept that accessibility sometimes costs more than pure efficiency.

The Kantian analysis reached a similar conclusion from a different direction. Kant's theory focuses on whether people are treated as ends in themselves rather than simply as a means to someone else's goal. In this case, Metra's goals of efficiency, modernization, and cost savings aren't automatically wrong. However, those goals become ethically questionable when some riders are expected to carry the burden of that modernization. If a rider's ability to use public

transportation depends on having the right phone, enough battery, working software, internet access, and digital payment, then the system isn't fully respecting every rider's needs.

Looking back at both analyses, the strongest conclusion I've come up with is that digital ticketing should be treated as one useful option, not as the center of the entire transportation system. A better approach would be to keep the Ventra app while also maintaining fair and dependable alternatives for people who can't use it or for moments when the technology fails. This could include clearer backup procedures for such scenarios, more consistent instructions for conductors, and some form of non-digital ticket access in all locations. These options may not appear to be as efficient as relying mainly on the app, but public transportation shouldn't only be judged by efficiency.

Overall, the Metra and Ventra case matters because it shows how easily technology can become required without people fully noticing. A system can seem modern and convenient while still making life harder for people who don't fit the assumed digital model. Public transportation is supposed to help people move through daily life, not make access depend on whether or not their phone works at the right moment. If public services are going to keep becoming more digital, they also need to stay responsible to the people who depend on them. Technology should make public transportation easier to access, not easier to be excluded from.

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